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Rhythm in Repose

You shouldn't just stream music, you should also travel for it. Here are some of the most exciting music festivals in the country

Kumbhalgarh Festival, Rajasthan

Celebrated in the winter months at the grand stage of the Kumbhalgarh Fort near Udaipur, this cultural festival has grown from strength to strength each year. The grand opening features traditional dances, puppet shows and various contests, while the daytime *haat* (festive market) offers locals a chance to display craft pieces from all over the state. When the sun goes down, the



venue transforms into a sensory spectacle with stunning dance and music performances.



International Yoga and Music Festival, Rishikesh

The yoga capital, Rishikesh, is also home to a spectacular fest that celebrates music along with yoga. Held over a period of seven days, the festival features workshops and sessions. The evenings are reserved for a curated dance and music line-up. The next in-person version of the event, organised by the Nada Yoga School, has been eagerly awaited ever since restrictions were lifted after the pandemic and crowd events resumed.

Hampi Utsav, Karnataka



This festival in Karnataka is huge in terms of audience number, and I can recollect performing before a sea of people, stretching from the stage to the Virupaksha Temple about half a kilometre away. The next edition of the festival will be held in the last week of January 2023 over three days, and will feature an array of cultural programmes, including a sound-and-light show, showcasing the glory of the Vijayanagara Empire.

Jodhpur RIFF, Jodhpur

This five-day roots music extravaganza, held at the Mehrangarh fort, RIFF (Rajasthan International Folk Festival), features some of the most visually dazzling music performances among festivals all over India. I performed at the RIFF twice, the first of which was with Rolling Stones frontman Mick Jagger in the audience (Jagger is the chief international patron of the festival). An impressive number of Rajasthani folk artists who have performed here have gone on to garner international acclaim, from Kutle Khan to Bhanwari Devi.

